

IT CORRIDOR

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Midnight bonfires

In areas off Old Mahabalipuram Road such as Thalambur and Ottiyambakkam, air quality is hugely compromised by burning of garbage



PRINCE FREDERICK

Often times, a problem never really leaves, let alone leave bag and baggage, just lingers around with a different and unrecognised face. It usually shifts its base to a nearby address, but returns to its old haunt with a vengeance taking on a virulent form, yet going unnoticed.

Ashok Rajendran, a resident of DABC Orchid in Polachery, has noticed this pattern play out in neighbouring Thalambur.

Based on his observations, a garbage dumping site in Thalambur was removed following protests from residents of large gated communities within whiffing distance of the recurring mucky mass. It was removed to a patch behind Agni College of Engineering, also in Thalambur, which marks the last outpost of the locality. Beyond this, addresses go un-

der Polachery, Ponmar and Ottiyambakkam.

Every time the residents of those gated communities in Thalambur heave a sigh of relief at the memory of the dump leaving their vicinity, they could be breathing in a draught of polluted air wafting in from that very dump, now relocated to this new patch. He derives this conclusion from his own experience.

Ashok notes that around midnight, this dump is set to fire, and when the wind blows in the direction of his high-rise apartment in Polachery, he could smell the smoke rising from the burning garbage pile.

Ashok admits to being unable to define the periodicity of the fires from this dump, but is certain the burning happens late in the night, and the effect can be felt in the wee hours.

Besides, at all times, one could see smouldering fire in the dump, underlines Ashok. Around this

patch, pylons rear high, supporting a high-tension power cable network.

Another unpalatable sight from his high-rise apartment is of garbage being set on fire in Ottiyambakkam. This is a distant view, notes Ashok, but clear as day, he can see fire and smoke rising at a garbage dump behind the Ottiyambakkam quarry.

In these panchayat-governed outlying areas off Old Mahabalipuram Road, coming under Chengalpattu district, poor waste management is an everyday reality. The advantage that comes from relatively lower automobile concentration is squandered away, the air being polluted by garbage fires, many of them happening in local civic body-instituted dump sites.

Not a first-time fire

Bernice Jacinth, a professional in the IT industry, regularly documents garbage fires, particularly



those happening in dump sites created by local panchayats.

Recently, she sent in images of smoke rising from a dump site instituted by Sithalapakkam panchayat on Mambakkam-Medavakkam Main Road, and this is not the first time she has witnessed a fire at that site.

Ashok notes that in outlying areas around OMR, massive apartments proliferate and un-

Garbage burning in Thalambur and (right) in Sithalapakkam.

less these bulk waste generators manage much their waste in situ, the garbage problem will keep getting out of hand.

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Incidents of cars getting trapped in flooded urban roadways and underpasses are common in the event of heavy rains and during NE monsoon, Chennai is a frequent witness to this scenario.

A team of engineering faculty members and student researchers at SSN College of Engineering in Kelambakkam has developed a safety mechanism that could significantly improve survival chances during such emergencies.

The innovation, titled 'Improved Escape Worthiness of Car Occupants Under Drowning Environment', introduces a roof-opening escape system designed to activate when a vehicle begins to submerge in water, addressing a critical safety gap where conventional car doors often fail to open due to external water pressure.

The innovation has been developed by S. Suresh Kumar, Associate Professor, Department of Mechanical Engineering, along with student researchers B. Vishal and Neil Ashwin Raj, both graduated from the college some years ago.

"When the students were in their second year of engineering they started working on this idea which is largely because of what they have seen around them. For instance, one student had a relative who got trapped in a burning vehicle," says Suresh Kumar, adding that the project got a grant recent-

Team from OMR college designs clever exit from sinking cars

SSN College of Engineering, which developed a roof-opening escape system, recently received a grant for the project



An image from Cyclone Michaung.

design focuses on early activation and a non-explosive hybrid control mechanism, ensuring safer and more reliable operation under high-risk conditions, said a release.

The technology has undergone extensive validation, including Computational Fluid Dynamics (CFD) simulations and full-scale real-time testing on a modified vehicle.

Suresh Kumar in a release said the innovation focuses on improving escape accessibility under such conditions, with the aim of enhancing passenger safety in real-world situations.

The team is now exploring opportunities for further development and industry collaboration to assess integration into future automotive safety systems, particularly for regions prone to flooding and water-related hazards, added the release.

ly, and it has got a patent too.

In vehicle submersion incidents, especially those involving cars, whether caused by floods or accidents near waterbodies or extreme weather conditions, there can be fatalities, as passengers are often unable to open doors or find viable exit routes within a limited time

window, says a press release.

Existing vehicle designs offer limited alternatives, often leaving occupants trapped inside.

The SSN-developed system uses a combination of sensors and a pneumatically controlled mechanism to detect submersion conditions and trigger the opening of the

vehicle's roof at an early stage. By enabling a wider and more accessible exit point, the system is designed to support faster evacuation for all occupants, including those seated in the rear.

Unlike conventional approaches that rely on smaller openings or electrically dependent systems, the

KCG College signs MoU with Urbaser



KCG College of Technology in Karapakkam has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Urbaser Sumeet, a waste management firm, to strengthen collaboration in sustainability and waste management.

The partnership aims to create a long-term, industry-integrated sustainability model by engaging students directly in addressing urban environmental challenges in the city, said a release.

The key focus areas include sustainability initiatives and environmental awareness, green inno-

vation and social responsibility, and practical exposure to urban sanitation and waste management.

The students will take part in clean-up drives, awareness campaigns, workshops, internships, innovation challenges, and hands-on waste management activities throughout upcoming academic cycles, the release added.

Anand Jacob Varghese, chairman of the Hindustan Group of Institutions, said there is a need for civic consciousness and environmental responsibility among students.

"Engineering education today must go beyond laboratories and classrooms. When our students walk alongside conservancy workers, manage waste drives, and design recycling solutions for their own city, they are not just learning – they are becoming the kind of engineers and citizens Chennai needs," said Anand.

Albert Gleiser Ignacio, managing director of Urbaser Sumeet, said the collaboration will promote the principles of Reduce, Reuse, and Recycle (3R), encouraging environmentally conscious practices among students.

Quiz for middle-school students

Chennai-based KSA Trust is inviting school teams for the second edition of 'Quiz Champions of Chennai - 2026'. Curated by expert quiz masters, this event is designed to educate and engage middle-school students by sharing champion stories and diverse areas of knowledge.

The 2025 event had 28 schools and 1,550 students participating in it. Winners received certificates, gift vouchers, and a plaque for their school.

Founded by the 30-year-old Chennai-based Chartered Accounting firm Kalyanasundaram Associates, since 2013 KSA Trust has been running its annual 'Champions of Chennai

Awards, where it honour individuals and organisations in Chennai who have made remarkable contributions across fields such as arts, education, healthcare, enterprise, social initiative, science, and sports. These are people who serve selflessly, often without recognition, yet profoundly impact our community, said a release.

It has recognised 77 such champions to date, and August 17, 2026, will mark its 13th year, added the release.

To learn more, please visit: www.championsofchennai.org. For any questions regarding the quiz, email rao@championsofchennai.org or call 98411 16216.



Repair Cafe workshop in Thoraipakkam

Repair Cafe Chennai will be conducting its next electrical workshop in Thoraipakkam on May 30; 10 a.m. to 1 p.m.

Open to all, the session will equip one to pick up hands-on skills. Check out their insta page [@repaircafe.tiruandchennai](https://www.instagram.com/repaircafe.tiruandchennai) to know about the workshop.

Recycling drive in RK Nagar and Mandaveli Raja Street draws participation from various other parts of Chennai including Anna Nagar, Velachery and Adyar

Communities unite for resource revival



the message about the drive through social media platforms.

People used this opportunity to give away their hardly-used pre-loved belongings and what they considered waste.

The old clothes collected during the drive were sent to the textile recovery facility of Spreco, where they will be given a fresh lease of life.

Other resources such as plastics, metal, e-waste, thermocol and paper were sent to the Material Recovery Facility, from where they will be sent for recycling; the end result being that the resource value of waste is revived and its entry into dumping grounds is delayed.

Together, three truckloads of resources were sent for revival.

Waste Tour

Volunteers at the drop points made sure everyone who came felt good about being part of the drive by explaining where their waste went and how it was revived.



Recyclable waste being unloaded from cars and lined up. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

GANGA SRIDHAR

On May 17, Team EcoConnectors's much-awaited Resource Revival Drive unfolded at sections of Mandaveli and R.A. Puram. Recycling partner Spreco shored up the exercise, which received generous buy-in from the communities of RK Nagar, Mandaveli Raja Street RWA, Ragamallika and Poonga View RWA.

The one-day drive, which was flagged off around 10 a.m. at RK Nagar and Mandaveli Raja Street, saw people thronging in cars loaded with things to give away, coming from far-off places such as Velachery, Anna Nagar, Teynampet and areas around

Mylapore, Mandaveli, R.A. Puram, Abhiramapuram and Adyar.

A few communities collected items within their apartments and sent their contributions through one of their residents.

Volunteers who dared the *Kathri Veyyil* (peak summer heat) to support the collection points were elated to see the kind of response from people and the enquiries about when the next drive would be held.

The vacation time was put to best use, with many children participating in the drive and helping in the decluttering of their houses. Children from Raja Street and RK Nagar also participated in creating awareness videos to spread

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Residents losing property or educational documents face protracted bureaucratic procedures before securing non-traceable certificates required for getting duplicate copies

LIFFY THOMAS

In Chennai, 20-25 Non-Traceable Certificates are issued a month by the Police Department, the list generally released on Thursdays. Sought by those who have lost any original property-related document or misplaced an educational certificate that cannot be traced, getting a Non-Traceable Certificate serves as an official document in such cases.

The Certificate is required to be submitted to apply for a duplicate copy to get claims and for other government-related transaction or to prevent any fraud.

In April 2022, then Director General of Police, C. Sylendra Babu, issued a circular listing out various guidelines that should be followed by the petitioner while seeking such a certificate, along with timelines that should be followed by the police department as well.

Many a time, the entire exercise extends for months with various departments including police station in the petitioner's area of jurisdiction, Sub Registrar Office and Central Crime Record Bureau in the picture.

Documents to submit

The petitioner is required to furnish certified copies of the documents that are lost (obtained within a month prior to the presentation of the petition at the police station from the Sub Registrar Office concerned). Along with this, a recent photograph of the petitioner, a copy of the Aadhar Card, Voter ID or Passport; and newspaper advertisements placed in an English and a vernacular paper are to be submitted.

In case of death of the legal owner of the property, his or her legal heir should present the petition along with death certificate issued by a local body and legal heir certificate issued by designated Revenue Authority.

An encumbrance certificate for the property in question, for the last 20 years or from the date of registra-

tion of missing document, obtained from the Sub Registrar office, must also be furnished.

The petitioner is also required to submit an undertaking along with the petition that if the missing document is traced later, the Station House Officer (SHO) will be intimated who in turn has to inform the Sub Registrar Office.

Once an application is submitted, the Station House Officer (SHO) issues a CSR to the petitioner.

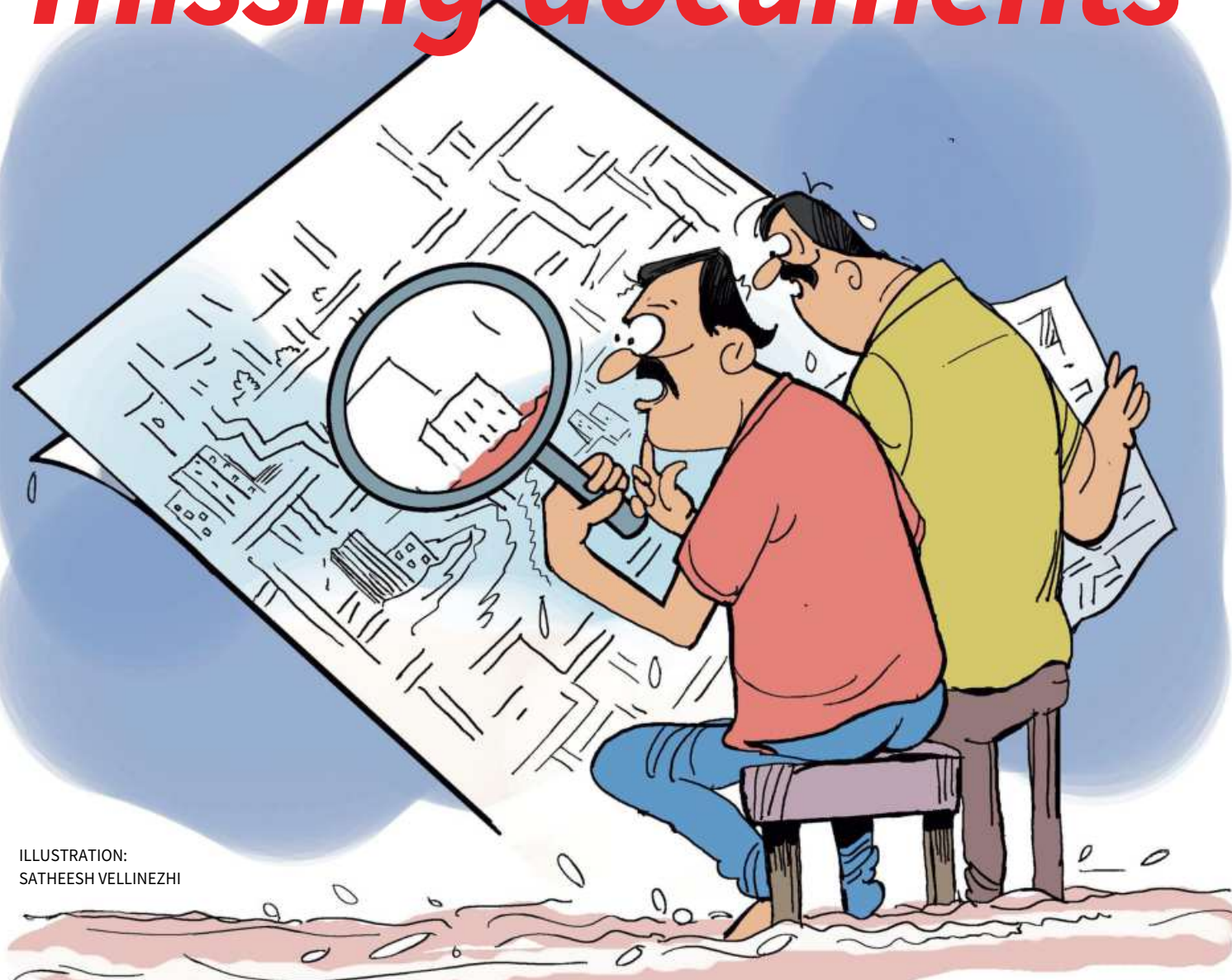
Later, a letter addressed to the Deputy Superintendent of Police/Assistant Commissioner of Police of the DCRB/CCRB is sent informing loss of document along with a certificate.

This is followed by publishing the matter in Crime and Occurrence Sheet within a week from the date of receipt of the letter from the SHO.

The circular insists all police stations to paste it on its notice board and state police website and CCTNS citizen portal to post the circular.

Applications for issuing a Non-Traceable Certificate are also accepted online.

ILLUSTRATION:
SATHEESH VELLINEZH



'A process that consumes time, induces tedium'

C.B. PAUL CHELLAKUMAR

From my own experience, I can say the procedures involved in getting a Non-Traceable Certificate is tiring, time-consuming and tedious.

I been running around for the last nine months to get the Certificate (CSR No 778 2025) despite producing all supporting documents.

Three officers who were handling my case were transferred and I am back to square one. Now, the new police officers at Thirumangalam Police Station who have taken charge are asking all the documents again as

those filed with the officers are not found. I cite this experience not to meet my ends but to help other petitioners who will be desperately running behind these three agencies, namely the Station House Officer (SHO), Commissioner of Police Office (CPO) and Sub-Registrar's Office (SRO).

The current system must be amended. For instance, the petitioner may be directed to file their petition with the Magistrate Court with all supportive documents, which could then be forwarded to the police station concerned, with proper instructions for action and report within a stipulated time. The magistrate on receipt of the re-

port with all supportive documents can issue the 'Non Traceable Certificate' instead of the SHO doing it.

General information on the procedures and documents required should be made available with every police station. The police personnel at stations are not familiar with the procedures and need proper orientation. The officer should also give acknowledgement for the documents received from the complainant as supportive documents for the loss of property documents also get lost at the police stations.

C.B. Paul Chellakumar is a resident of 13th Main Road, Anna Nagar



The squalor marking one side of TP Scheme Road.
PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK



Not the view they had bargained for

PRINCE FREDERICK

Poonga View Residents Welfare Association: when they christened their RWA thus, residents of TP Scheme Road in Mandaveli had in mind categories of “views” diametrically opposite to what they are being treated to.

TP Scheme Road is 300 metres long, and one side of the road has a wall, one bounding the Adyar Poonga. It means there are habitations on only one side of the road.

A careless count puts it at 50; sparsely populated, one would expect serenity. And nature rearing up on one side meant the eyes have a pleasant object to focus on.

Here are the categories of “views” they are actually treated to on a daily basis, as listed by members of Poonga View RWA. Open urination along the wall. Unauthorised parking along the wall. When the TASMAC outlet was on Venkatakrishna Road in Mandaveli, tipplers would turn the space by the

wall into an open bar, and some of them would make it a “bed” for a stupefied, post-alcohol slumber. As reported by residents, there would also be other forms of substance abuse behind the illegally parked vehicles, some of them abandoned. Couples would also arrive in cars. Besides, the trees in the Poonga that were expected to give them a pleasant view, would ironically add to the problems. The leaves they shed, along with those shrugged off by the avenue trees on

TP Scheme Road, would accumulate by the side of the wall, as parked vehicles would mean the Urbaser Summit workers cannot clear the putrefying muck. There would be garbage as well, according to a member of the RWA. Repetiles feel at home in this muck.

This road falls in ward 171, Zone 13, and these residents have taken the matter to the councillor, and earlier even escalated it to the previous MLA.

And they are still waiting for all

these problems to be resolved.

This is how a member of Poonga View RWA puts it: “This has been the scene for many years with no action taken by the government even after many complaints to Greater Chennai Corporation. They keep pointing at the other officials for not doing their job. We want to bring this to the notice of CM Vijay so that there will be some action by the new government that could solve our long-pending problems.”

Rotary District 3233 along with a smart educational learning platform is offering a free NEET online test practice series in Tamil and English before the retest on June 21

LIFFY THOMAS

Many students have returned to coaching institutes after the National Testing Agency cancelled the NEET 2026 held on May 3 and inked in a retest for June 21. One would be lucky if the institute they have associated with in the last one to two years is only charging a nominal fee or no fee at all for this additional period.

A neat solution



Students at a centre in College on May 3. PHOTO: RAGU R

For those who cannot afford to get back to the classroom and need some quick help with question banks and test papers, here is a platform that comes free of cost.

QB365, a smart educational learning platform, with the support of Rotary District 3233, has launched a free NEET online test

practice series for students in Tamil Nadu.

The initiative aims to help students regain confidence, reduce examination fear, improve exam readiness, and continue their preparation in a positive and structured manner.

According to a press release, Ta-

mil Nadu has one of the highest NEET candidates appearing, with approximately 1.55 lakh students registered for NEET UG 2026. A significant number of students are from rural backgrounds, Tamil-medium schools, and from economically weaker sections who find it difficult to get accessible and affordable academic support.

Purushothaman, a Rotary member and founder of QB365, says they have uploaded 14,000 questions along with answers in all the three subjects in both Tamil and English.

This also includes question papers from previous years and other sample papers based on NCERT syllabus.

He says the platform will be

helpful for students who cannot afford to spend money until the NEET retest but at the same time want to stay updated on what they have learnt. “We are not a coaching institute or tutors but we offer practice exams,” he says.

Once a person logs in there are topic wise test papers. A person need to upload their NEET hall ticket to get access to the test papers.

Besides daily and weekly NEET practice tests with mobile-friendly online access, the platform would also give a performance analysis based on the scores.

Rotarian P. Jayanathan, Chennai coordinator and RI District -Additional Director, says the 30-day course will also offer instant results. Last year, Rotary had a similar tie-up with the educational platform but was charging students a small fee. This year, we are offering it free seeing the stress that students are undergoing with retest and to keep their medical dream alive, says Jayanathan.



In Nanmangalam, where a lake and a reserve forest are located cheek by jowl, the view may not be picture-perfect, being marred by garbage dumping and sewage inflow. But the picture is eye-catching as well, thanks to people's participation in improving conditions and its wildlife. Around International Day for Biological Diversity (May 22), a close look at the patch and its people

Between a lake and a forest

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

The health of a lake is directly proportional to the acts of positive reciprocity it receives from the people it serves. Its health is also predicated on the pride it instils in those people. The Nanmangalam lake is presented with a mixed bag. It is subjected to abuse by those in a position of stewardship towards it, but it also has two groups of people that make sure it stays in the news, its charms being extolled and its blights highlighted. And their groups vary in their composition, but their have found a point of intersection where goals unite into one: preserving and cherishing the Nanmangalam lake.

Kumaresan Chandrabose is part of the local residents group, largely drawn from Sembakkam, Nanmangalam and Hastinapuram that has been documenting the biodiversity of the lake as well as the Nanmangalam Reserve forest that overlooks it, actually the rim of the forest. Through photography and videography, he has documented a wide range of resident and migratory species around the lake, as have most other members of this hyperlocal naturalist group. People outside this group also join nature walks.

According to Kumaresan, bird-watching has changed the way people view the lake.

The list of birds recorded at Nanmangalam is extensive. Among them are the Chestnut-winged Cuckoo, Asian Paradise

Flycatcher, Yellow Bittern, Painted Snipe, Black Bittern, Watercock, Long-toed Stint and Oriental Magpie Robin. Darters are also regularly spotted across the lake.

One species that particularly stands out is the Chestnut-winged Cuckoo, a migratory bird that has been in Nanmangalam as its winter destination.

Kumaresan also described the Watercock as one of the more unusual birds found within Chennai Metropolitan area. Yellow Bittern nesting sites and Darter breeding activity have also been observed around the wetland. Interestingly, some migratory birds move into nearby

residential areas as well. The Blue-throated Blue Flycatcher, for instance, has been repeatedly spotted near

a temple inside a nearby apartment complex.

Beyond birds, he tracks butterflies and odonates around the lake, several of which have become harder to find.

A butterfly called the Joker, which depends on a native host plant called Tragia, locally known as Sendatti, is becoming scarce around the lake. Though the plant is often removed because it causes skin irritation, Kumaresan says it plays an important ecological role.

"In the name of beautification, many of these native bushes are being removed," he says.

Waste dumping is another negative factor.

No time to 'waste'

Over time, worsening environmental damage pushed a group of residents and volunteers to come together under the "Saving Nanmangalam Lake" initiative, a citizen-led movement launched in June 2024 to protect the lake and create awareness about its ecological

importance.

Among those leading these efforts are Jayapriya Ramanathan and R. Sathya, both residents of Sembakkam who have been actively involved in cleanup drives and awareness campaigns around the lake. According to organisers, untreated sewage inflow, encroachments, garbage dumping, and poor waste management remain some of the biggest threats facing the ecosystem today.

Another challenge, according to the organisers, is the lake's fragmented administration. Portions of the lake fall within the limits of different local civic bodies (in-

cluding the Tambaram Corporation), making coordinated restoration efforts challenging. "All the departments need to work together collectively," says Jayapriya, stressing that both the lake and adjoining reserve

forest require integrated protection measures.

A major concern is the garbage transit point established between the reserve forest and the lake by a panchayat. The site functions as a dumping and transportation area for municipal waste.

"We have seen cattle consuming plastic waste," says Sathya, adding that birds and other animals are also likely being affected by the pollution. This scenario makes biomagnification real.

Sathya also points out untreated sewage continues entering the waterbody.

In response, the initiative has focused heavily on community participation. Volunteers organise cleanup drives, awareness

campaigns, walkathons, meetings with officials, and waste segregation programmes. Residents are encouraged to reduce plastic usage, segregate waste properly and switch to cloth or jute bags.

A large awareness walkathon conducted earlier this year reportedly saw participation from nearly 600 volunteers.

Organisers say these efforts have started making a visible difference. In some stretches, garbage dumping has reduced, warning boards have been installed, and partial fencing work has been completed along the South Bund Road.

"Initially, many people believed nothing would change," Jayapriya says. "Gradually, public participation and awareness began to increase."

Though residents joined the initiative at different stages, the core volunteer group now consists of around 15 active members working consistently on the ground. Elderly residents who are unable to participate physically contribute through paperwork and coordination with government departments.

The movement has also expanded beyond the lake. Organisers recently formed the Vanam and Neer Foundation to support conservation efforts involving both the wetland and the Nanmangalam Reserve Forest.

Still, challenges remain. Waste often reappears after cleanup drives, and urban pressure around the lake continues to intensify. Conservation efforts, they say, cannot depend on volunteers alone.

Beauty and squalor coexist.

(Clockwise from top) An Oriental magpie robin in a pile of garbage; the dumping site; and a Painted snipe and a plastic discard. PHOTOS: KUMARESAN CHANDRABOSE & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Advanced robotic surgery performed



The team of surgeons and anaesthetists who performed the surgery.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A robotic nephrectomy was performed on a three-year-old child using the SSI Mantra 3, a robotic surgical platform at Murugan Hospital, Kilpauk.

The surgery was led by Dr. Raghul M, a paediatric surgeon, along with assistant surgeon Dr. Sabari, and supported by SSI Mantra robotic technician Vishal Pandian. The anesthesia team was headed by Dr. Karthikeyan.

According to a release, the child had been suffering from recurrent urinary tract infections due to a rare congenital urological abnormality – a non-functioning left kidney associated with a grossly dilated and tortuous ectopic ureter draining

into the vagina.

Using robotic-assisted minimally invasive surgery, the diseased kidney and abnormal ureter were removed through tiny incisions. The procedure was completed successfully in approximately one hour, with minimal blood loss and excellent intraoperative stability, the release added.

Dr. Raghul said, "Robotic technology is gradually transforming the way complex paediatric surgical procedures are performed. In young children, precision becomes extremely important due to limited working space and delicate anatomical structures."

The hospital is located on Kilpauk Garden Road. Phone: 044 4644 8989.

Poorvika, an Indian tech and appliance omnichannel retailer, recently opened its 48th showroom on IT Corridor.

The new showroom offers TVs, refrigerators, washing machines, air conditioners, mobile phones, and laptops at attractive prices and exciting launch offers, said a release.

Customers can avail free home delivery, assured gifts, exchange bonuses of up to ₹12,000, and ₹5,000 in gold vouchers on purchases above ₹1 lakh.

When a consumer purchases a 75-inch Smart TV, they receive a complimentary soundbar worth ₹21,999. A double-door re-

Poorvika comes to IT Corridor



frigerator entitles a kitchen pan worth ₹3,999, along with an exchange bonus of up to ₹6,000, the release said.

Plus ₹1 down payment EMI options, free installation for select brands, and exclusive credit/debit card offers.

The showroom is located at Old No: 141, New No: 288, Old Mahabalipuram Road, near IDBI Bank, Kandanchavadi.

For details, call 99406 88855.

Workshop on organic farming



Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is organising a culinary workshop on making soups on May 27. According to a press release, the programme will have demonstrations on preparations of soups from tubers, greens, herbs, and millets.

Another workshop on organic farming of vegetable crops will be held on May 29. The session will focus on chemical-free methods of soil nourishment and pest and disease management.

The essentials and procedure of organic certification will be taught, adds the release. Both the workshops will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, First Floor, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy.

For details, call 044 - 29530048

MSME conducts workshops

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute - Tamil Nadu is organising a training programme on making chemical products. The products include: black phenyl, grease, disinfectants, and detergents meant for cleaning and washing floor, water tank, pipes, utensils, and clothes. The session will be held from May 25 to 27.

The institute is also conducting another workshop on making value-added products from Moringa. The session will be held on May 29.

Both the programmes will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, Ekkattuthangal. For details, call 8668102600.

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